Sylvia

How to use Sylvia

A beginner's guide to the 12-month planner, updated November 2026

Welcome

Sylvia is a free planner that helps a beginner learn to invest over 12 months without paying for early mistakes. You practise on paper first, you write down why you do everything, and the tools stop you when you are about to break your own rules. It follows the ideas in Benjamin Graham's *The Intelligent Investor*, paraphrased, and is not affiliated with the book's author or publisher.

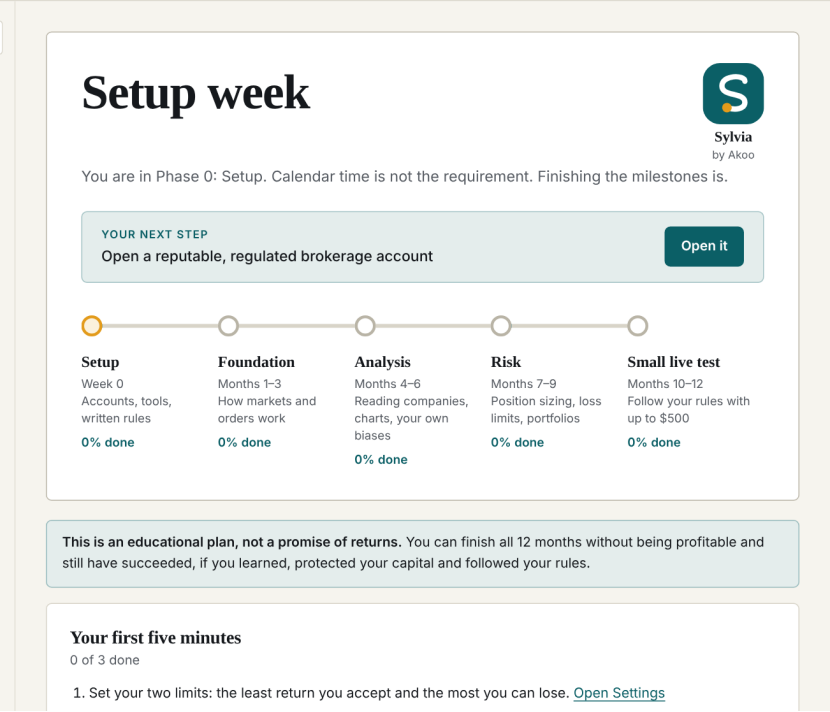
> **Who it is for**
> Cautious beginners. It is **not** a stock-tip service, not a day-trading tool and not financial advice. Nothing in Sylvia recommends any security, and nothing in it predicts returns.

Three things to know before you start

- **Your data stays on your device.** Everything you enter is saved in your browser. There are no accounts and nothing is sent to a server. The only outside request is for two typefaces from Google Fonts.
- **It can be lost.** Clearing your browser data, or using another browser or device, means your entries are not there. Export a backup (section 12). Sylvia reminds you after 7 days.
- **There are no live prices.** Sylvia cannot fetch market data. You type prices in yourself, and the app labels each one as manual with its date.

1. Your first five minutes

Open the site and press **Start the 12-month plan**. You land on the dashboard. New users see a card called **Your first five minutes** with three steps. It disappears when all three are done.



The dashboard on a new account: the next step, the five phases, and the first-five-minutes card.

Step	Where	Why it matters
1. Set your two limits: the least return you accept and the most you can lose	Settings	Live trades are blocked until both are written down. They keep you honest when a trade goes badly.
2. Log one paper trade with a stop and a reason	Trade Journal	A trade with a stop, shares, reason and a line on what would prove you wrong counts as complete.
3. Export a backup	Settings	Your data is only in this browser. A backup protects weeks of work.

The dashboard also shows **Your next step** for the phase you are in, your progress through the five phases, a Practice trades card from your journal, a Portfolio card, and any red flags.

2. The menu, group by group

On a phone, tap the menu button at the top left. The menu has five groups.

Group	Page	What it is for
Top	Dashboard	Your next step, progress, practice trades, portfolio summary and reminders.
Phases	0 Setup, 1 Foundation, 2 Analysis, 3 Risk, 4 Small live test	The 12-month course. Each phase has milestones and a gate you pass before advancing.
Phases	Investor type	Three questions on whether you are a defensive or an enterprising investor. Most people are defensive.
Portfolio	Portfolio	Holdings, cash, allocation and results, calculated from your transactions.
Portfolio	Transactions	Record every buy, sale, dividend, deposit, withdrawal and fee.
Portfolio	12-month planner	Monthly tasks, planned contributions, quarterly reviews and goals.
Portfolio	Financial tools	Eight calculators for growth, retirement, inflation, dividends, allocation, risk and averaging.
Practice	Trade Journal	Record every paper or live trade with its reason, risk plan and process review.
Practice	Metrics	Win rate, expectancy, R-multiples, drawdown, rule adherence, recurring mistakes.
Practice	Thesis Builder	A one-page decision document you write before you own a business.
Practice	Position Calculator	How many shares you can buy from the amount you can afford to lose.
Practice	Watchlist	Five to ten companies and broad funds you are studying. A filter, not a shopping list.
Practice	Weekly Review	One page a week: the journal fills in numbers, you fill in the honest part.
Graham	Investment or speculation, Margin of safety, Defensive screener, Mr. Market, Allocation policy, Graham lessons	Tools and 28 short lessons based on The Intelligent Investor.
Reference	About Sylvia, Red Flags, Resources, Glossary, Plan Report, Help and legal, Settings	Overview, warnings from your own entries, reading list, terms, a printable report, pricing and privacy, and your data.

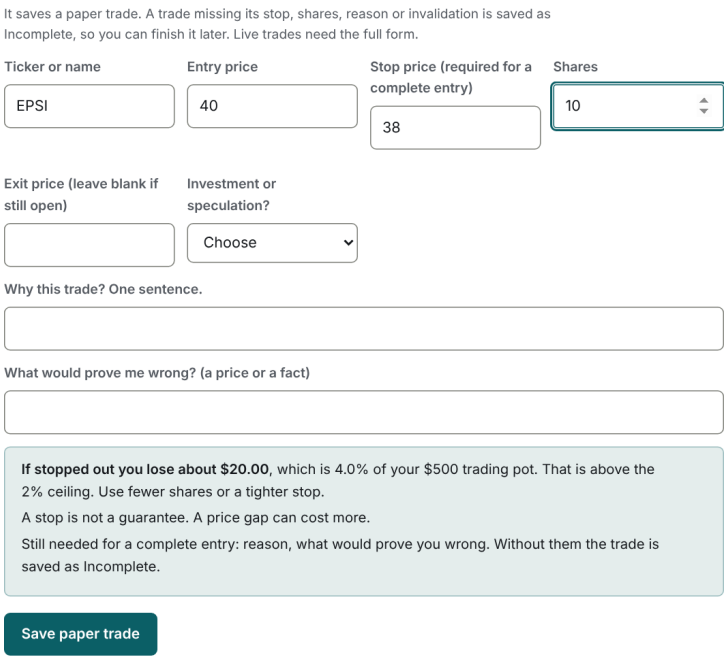
3. The 12 months and the five phases

Phase	When	Focus	Real money?
0 Setup	Week 0	Accounts, tools, written rules. $4,500 of a $5,000 pot stays out of trading entirely.	No
1 Foundation	Months 1 to 3	How markets and orders work. A short daily routine.	No, paper only
2 Analysis	Months 4 to 6	Reading companies and charts, spotting your own biases, writing a thesis for every idea.	No, paper only
3 Risk	Months 7 to 9	Position sizing, loss limits, an allocation, a written trading plan.	No, paper only
4 Small live test	Months 10 to 12	Optional. Follow your rules with up to $500 of real money.	Yes, small

- Each phase has **milestones** and a **gate**. Calendar time is not the requirement. Finishing the milestones is.
- The "simulated trades" milestone counts practice orders **and** complete paper trades from your journal. Incomplete or live trades do not count.
- Phase 0 asks you to read the first-year restrictions: no borrowing to trade, no options or leveraged funds, no penny stocks or crypto speculation inside this plan.
- You can stay in simulation as long as you need. Phase 4 is optional.

4. The Trade Journal

The journal is the most important page in Sylvia. Use **Quick paper trade** for fast entries. Use **Add a trade** (the full form) for live trades or extra detail.



The quick form. The box under the fields shows what a stop-out would cost and what is still missing.

What a complete entry has

- **Entry price**, **stop price** (where you get out if you are wrong) and **shares**.
- **Why this trade** in one sentence, and **what would prove me wrong**: a price or a fact that ends the idea.
- **Investment or speculation?** If you cannot decide, choose unclear.

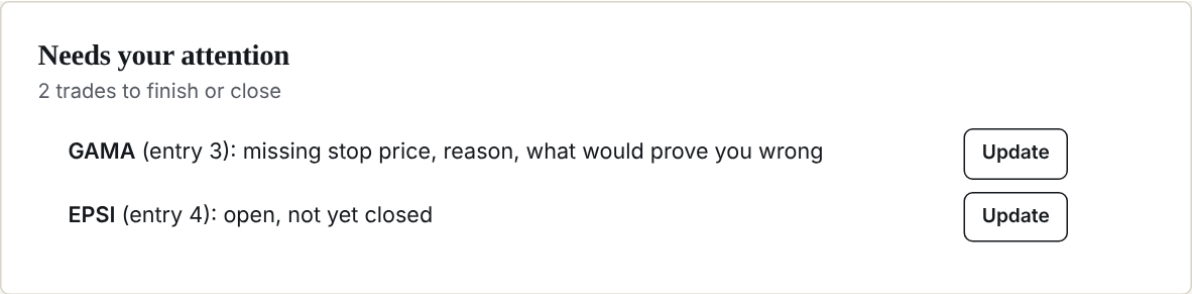
While you type, Sylvia shows the dollar risk and what share of your trading pot it is. Above 2% it warns you to use fewer shares or a tighter stop. A stop is not a guarantee: a price gap can cost more.

The rules

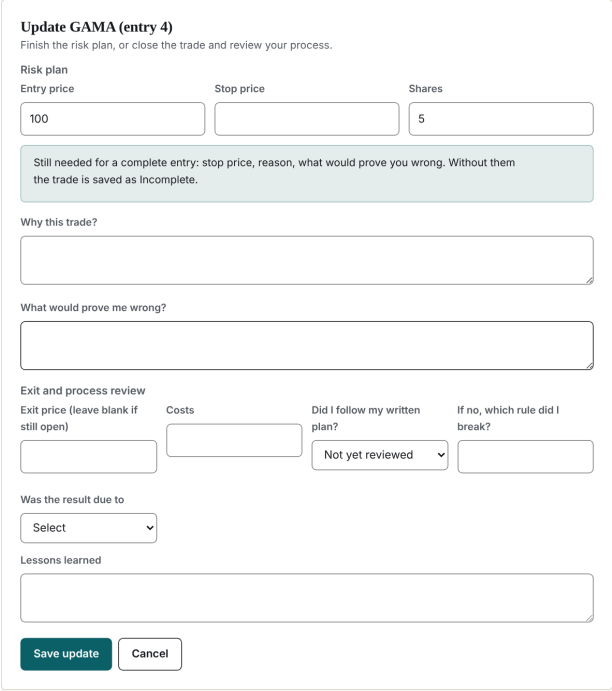
Situation	What happens
Live trade missing a stop, shares, reason or invalidation	Blocked, with a message saying what is missing.
Closed live trade with no answer to "Did I follow my written plan?"	Blocked.
Live trade before your two limits are set	Blocked until you set them in Settings.
Paper trade missing any of those	Saved as **Incomplete**, with a notice, an entry under Needs your attention and a red flag.
Paper trade with an exit price but no process review	Saved as Incomplete: needs process review.
Stop at or above the entry	Warning. For a normal purchase the stop goes below the entry.

Finishing and closing a trade

At the top of the journal, **Needs your attention** lists every incomplete or open trade with an **Update** button.



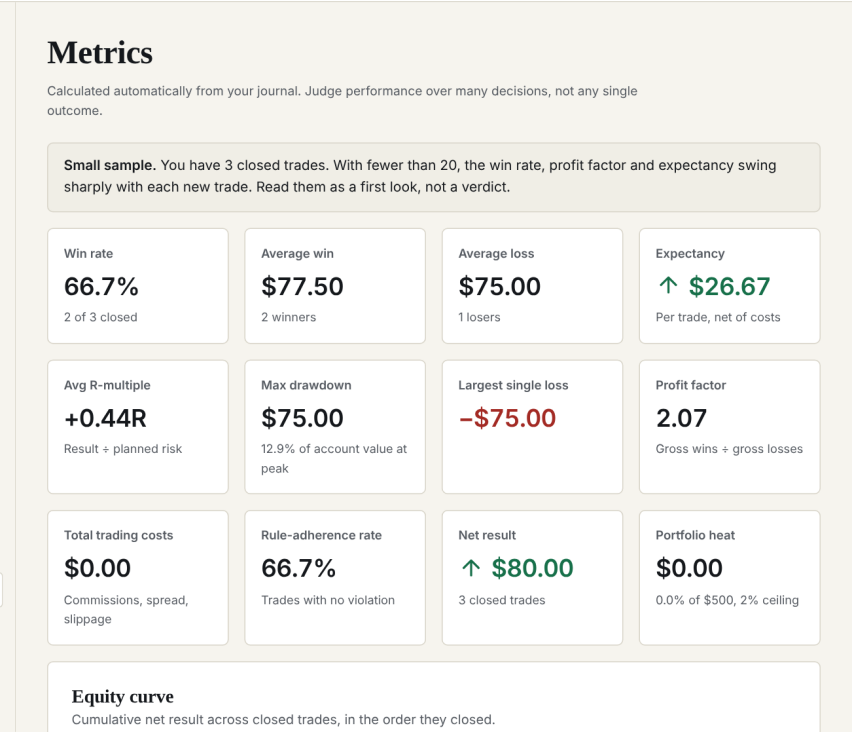
Needs your attention: each trade that is incomplete or still open has an Update button.



The Update panel: finish the risk plan, enter the exit price and review your process.

- To **close** a trade, enter the exit price and answer **Did I follow my written plan?**. If you answer no, say which rule you broke.
- Then choose whether the result was due to **your process**, **new facts** or **luck**.
- The table shows **Process** next to the result. A winning trade where you broke your plan is flagged as a rule-breaking win. Do not count it as a success.

5. Metrics and red flags



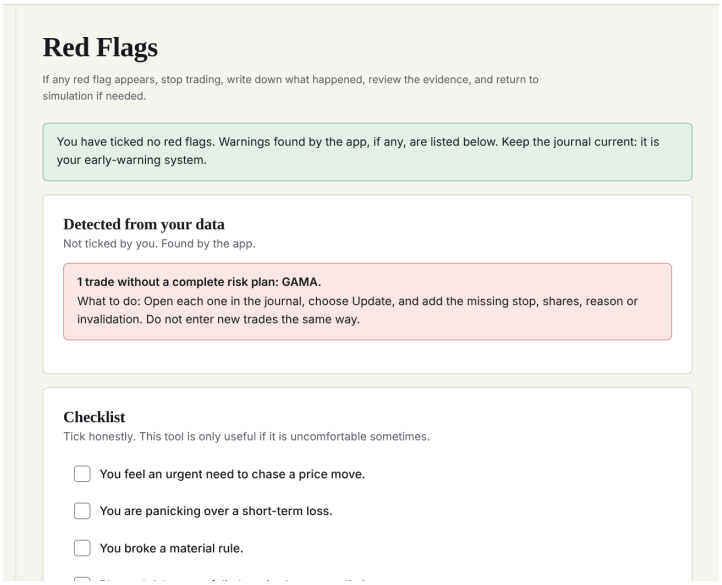
The Metrics page, calculated from your closed trades. The example trades are invented.

Number	Plain meaning
Win rate	The share of closed trades that made money.
Expectancy	The average result per trade after costs. Positive means your wins outweigh your losses on average.
R-multiple	Result divided by the amount you planned to risk. +1.5R means you made one and a half times your planned risk. n/a means no stop was set, so risk is unknown.
Profit factor	Total wins divided by total losses. Above 1 means wins are larger.
Max drawdown	The biggest fall from a peak in your running total, shown as a share of account value at the peak (your starting capital plus the peak profit).
Rule-adherence rate	Closed trades with no rule broken. Compare it with your win rate.
Portfolio heat	Total planned loss if every open stop were hit. The ceiling is 2% of your trading pot.

With fewer than 20 closed trades the app shows a **Small sample** notice. The numbers swing with every trade, so read them as a first look.

Red flags

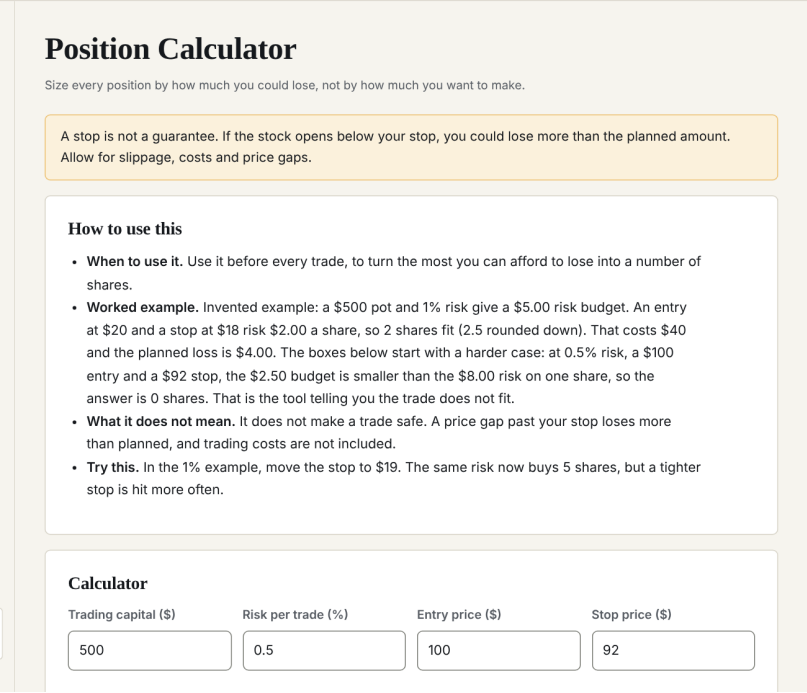
The Red Flags page has two parts: a checklist you tick yourself (for example "I broke a material rule" or "I am averaging down to avoid admitting I was wrong"), and warnings the app finds in your entries, each with what to do next. Examples are two or more price-driven decisions in 30 days, trades without a complete risk plan, and a rule-breaking win. Warnings stop appearing once you fix the cause.



The Red Flags page.

6. Thesis, position size, watchlist and weekly review

- **Thesis Builder.** A thesis is a decision document, not an excuse for buying something you already want. A thesis cannot be marked Buy until its checks are done.
- **Position Calculator.** Enter your trading capital, the risk per trade, the entry and the stop. It tells you how many shares fit inside the loss you can afford, rounded down. If the answer is 0, the trade does not fit. Do not raise your risk percentage to make the numbers work.
- **Watchlist.** Start with 5 to 10 companies and broad funds. It is a filter, not a shopping list.
- **Weekly Review.** Seven days, one page. Your journal fills in the numbers and you answer honestly whether your decisions were businesslike, whatever the outcome.

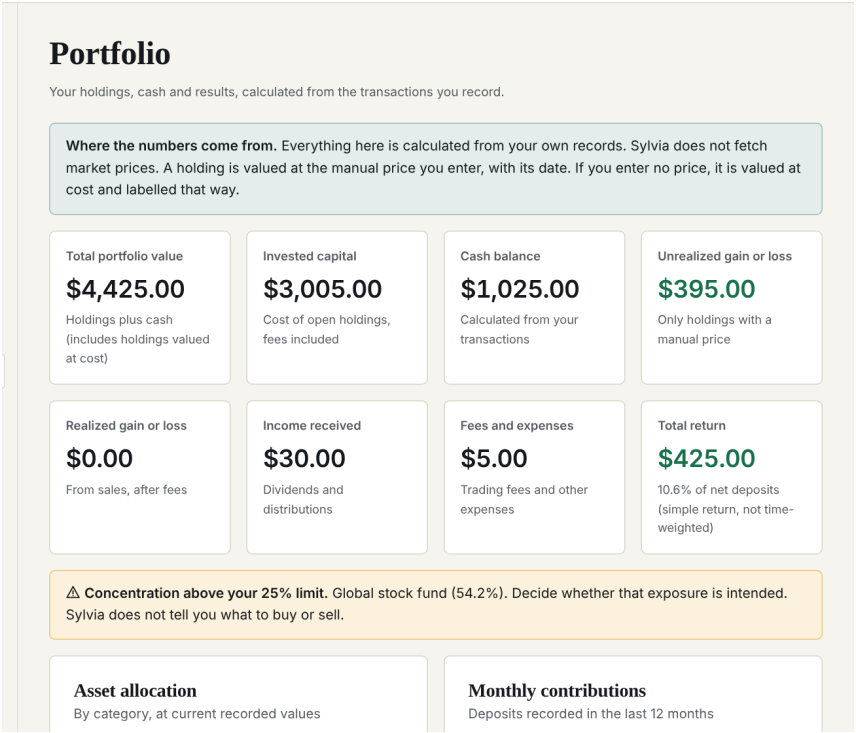


The Position Calculator with its How to use this card.

7. Portfolio and Transactions

Use these pages to track what you actually own. Your portfolio is **calculated from the transactions you record**, so the order is: add an asset, record a deposit, then record the purchase.

- **Portfolio, add an asset:** name, optional ticker, a category (stock, ETF, bond or your own), a unit and an optional manual price with its date.
- **Transactions:** choose the type. Buys and sales need an asset, quantity, price and fee. Dividends need an asset and an amount. Deposits, withdrawals and fees need only an amount. Dates cannot be in the future.
- A sale larger than the quantity you held on that date is rejected. Deleting an asset also deletes its transactions, after a confirmation.

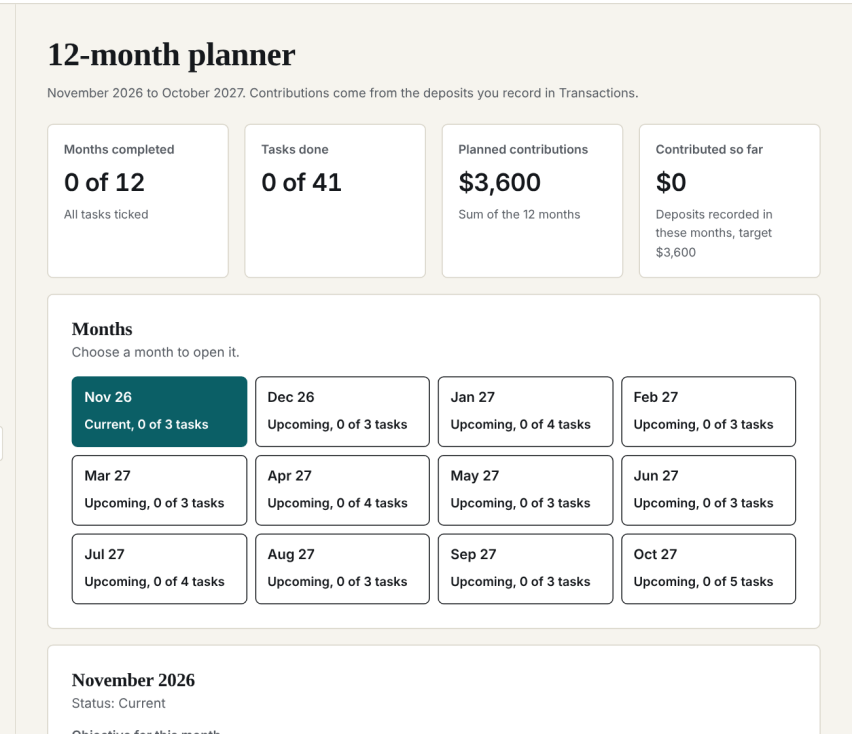


The Portfolio page with invented example data.

Number	How it is worked out
Holdings and cost	Average cost method. Fees are included in the cost.
Value	Quantity times your manual price. With no price entered it is valued at cost and labelled "at cost".
Cash balance	Deposits, minus withdrawals, minus purchases and fees, plus sale proceeds and dividends. If it is negative, record the deposit that paid for your purchases.
Unrealized gain or loss	Shown only for holdings that have a manual price.
Total return	Total value plus cash, minus net deposits. It is a simple return, not time-weighted, so timing of deposits is not adjusted for.
Concentration warning	Shown when one holding passes the limit you set (25% to start). It is a prompt to think, not an instruction to trade.

Valuation history comes from snapshots you record yourself, so it is not market history. Transactions and holdings export as CSV.

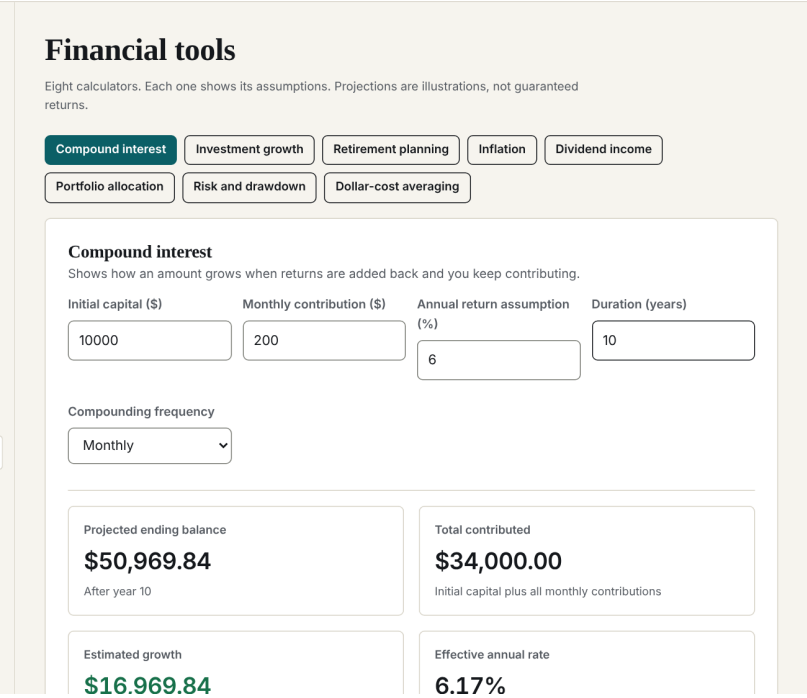
8. The 12-month planner



The planner after creating a plan, with invented example data.

- **Create the plan:** choose the first month, a planned monthly contribution and an optional yearly target.
- Each month starts with three tasks: review portfolio and transactions, check allocation, check risk. Months 3, 6, 9 and 12 add a quarterly review, and the last month adds an annual summary. You can add, tick and delete tasks.
- **Contributed** is not typed in. It comes from deposits you record in Transactions, dated in that month.
- Months show a text status: Done (all tasks ticked), Missed (past with open tasks), Current or Upcoming.
- **Goals** compare a target value with your total portfolio value. You can edit or delete them.
- **Reminders** appear on the dashboard when you open the app. Sylvia cannot send notifications.
- **Print or save the summary** from the planner for your records. Deleting the plan does not touch your portfolio.

9. Financial tools



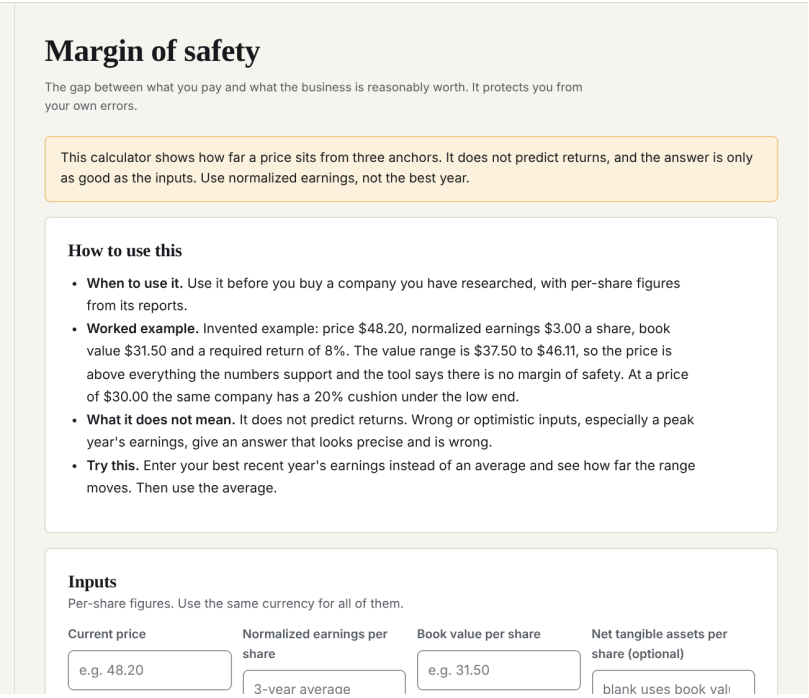
Financial tools: choose a calculator with the buttons at the top.

Calculator	Use it to
Compound interest	See how a lump sum plus monthly saving grows.
Investment growth	Compare a low, base and high return assumption side by side.
Retirement planning	Check the direction of long-term saving at two retirement ages, in future and today's money.
Inflation	See what a future sum may buy and the real return after inflation.
Dividend income	Estimate income from shares and the dividend per payment.
Portfolio allocation	Compare holdings with targets and see concentration. Press Fill from my portfolio to use your recorded holdings.
Risk and drawdown	See what a fall does and what gain it takes to recover. A 50% fall needs a 100% gain.
Dollar-cost averaging	Compare investing the same amount each time with the average of the prices you list.

Every calculator has a **How to use this** card: when to use it, a worked example taken from its own starting numbers, what the result does not mean, and something to try. Projections are illustrations, not forecasts. The starting numbers are invented.

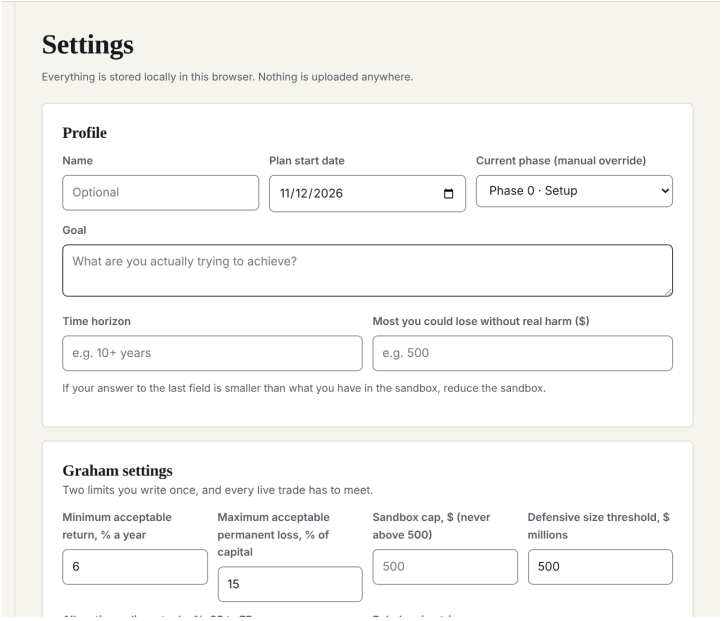
10. The Graham tools

- **Investment or speculation.** Graham's test: an investment, on thorough analysis, promises safety of your money and an adequate return. Anything else is speculation. Label your trades honestly.
- **Margin of safety.** Enter a price, normalized earnings per share and book value per share. The tool compares the price with three anchors (asset floor, earnings power, and the Graham Number as a ceiling) and shows how far the price sits from the low end of the range. It does not predict returns. Use average earnings, not a peak year.
- **Defensive screener.** Eight plain tests for a company you might hold for years. Passing proves little. Failing tells you where the risk is.
- **Mr. Market.** Imagine a partner who offers to buy or sell at prices that swing with his mood. Log the market's mood and your own, and count the times you tried to forecast.
- **Allocation policy.** Choose a stock and bond split between 25% and 75% and write the trigger for rebalancing. Then let the rule decide.
- **Graham lessons.** Twenty-eight short paraphrased ideas, each tied to something the app does. About twenty minutes in total.



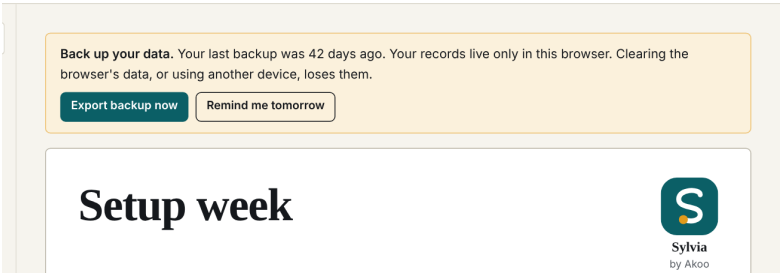
The Margin of safety tool with its How to use this card.

11. Settings, backups and moving devices



Settings. The Data card has export, import and reset.

- **Settings** holds your goals, time horizon, the two limits (least return you accept, most you can lose) and your trading capital.
- **Export all data (JSON)** saves a backup file named with today's date. Do this at least weekly. The Data card shows the date of your last backup.
- **Import data (JSON)** restores a backup and replaces what is on this device after a confirmation. A damaged file is rejected and your data is kept.
- **Moving between phone and computer:** export on one, import on the other. Each device keeps its own data and they do not sync.
- **Reset everything** asks twice and tells you how many entries will be erased.



The backup reminder that appears after 7 days, or if you have never backed up.

12. Troubleshooting

What you see	What it means and what to do
My entries are gone	The browser data was cleared, or this is a different browser or device. Import your latest backup.
The page looks the same after an update	Hard refresh: Ctrl+Shift+R on a computer, or close and reopen the tab on a phone. Updates can take a minute or two to appear.
Position Calculator says 0 shares	The risk on one share is bigger than your risk budget. Tighten the stop only if the idea supports it, find another setup, or skip the trade.
A trade says Incomplete	It is missing a stop, shares, reason, invalidation or process review. Open Needs your attention and press Update.
I cannot save a live trade	It needs a stop, shares, a reason and what would prove you wrong, and your two limits set in Settings.
A sale is rejected	You are selling more than you held on that date. Check the quantity and the date, or record the missing purchase.
A holding says valued at cost	No manual price entered. Add one with its date.
Cash balance is negative	Record the deposit that paid for your purchases.
Drawdown looks high	It is measured against your starting capital plus the peak profit. A $125 fall on a $580 peak is 21.6%.
I cannot advance a phase	Open the phase and tick the missing milestones. Written milestones need a few sentences.

13. What Sylvia does not do

- It does not fetch live prices. It has no server and no accounts.
- It does not sync between devices. Use export and import.
- It does not time-weight returns. Total return is a simple measure.
- It does not tell you what to buy or sell, and it cannot predict returns.
- It is not a regulated financial service. The pricing, privacy, terms and disclaimer pages under Help and legal are plain-language summaries that a lawyer should review before any paid launch.

14. A simple routine

How often	What to do
Each trade	Quick paper trade with stop, reason and invalidation. Close it with the process review when it ends.
Each day (5 minutes)	Log Mr. Market's mood and your own. Do not forecast.
Each week	Weekly Review, then read Metrics and Red Flags. Export a backup.
Each month	Open the planner month, tick its tasks, record contributions, check allocation and risk, record a portfolio snapshot.
Each quarter	Do the quarterly review task and check your goals.

These are suggestions, not requirements. Use what helps you.

Feedback
Report a bug or suggest a feature from **Help and legal** in the menu. It opens a GitHub page. Do not post account numbers or personal financial details.

Not financial advice
Sylvia is an educational planner. Nothing here recommends any investment. All example numbers in this guide are invented.